Live music events in the UK

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Live music events in the UK

- **The UK is a global centre for live music**
  - Offers a diverse range of events, including festivals, gigs, and club nights
  - Hosts events throughout the year, appealing to fans of all genres
  - Plays a key role in the UK's cultural identity and tourism industry
  - Features both international superstars and emerging local talent
  - Organisers range from independent founders to major promoters like Live Nation and Festival Republic

Major UK music festivals

Festival	Information
• **Glastonbury Festival (Somerset)**	• Started in 1970 by Michael Eavis; now co-organised with daughter Emily • Attracts around 200,000 attendees annually • Covers a wide range of genres: rock, pop, electronic, world music, etc
• **Reading and Leeds Festivals**	• Known for rock, punk, metal, and indie line-ups ○ Organised by Festival Republic; runs simultaneously in two cities
• **Download Festival (Donington Park)**	• Focuses on heavy metal and hard rock • A favourite for fans of bands like Metallica, Iron Maiden and Slipknot

Stuck on something?

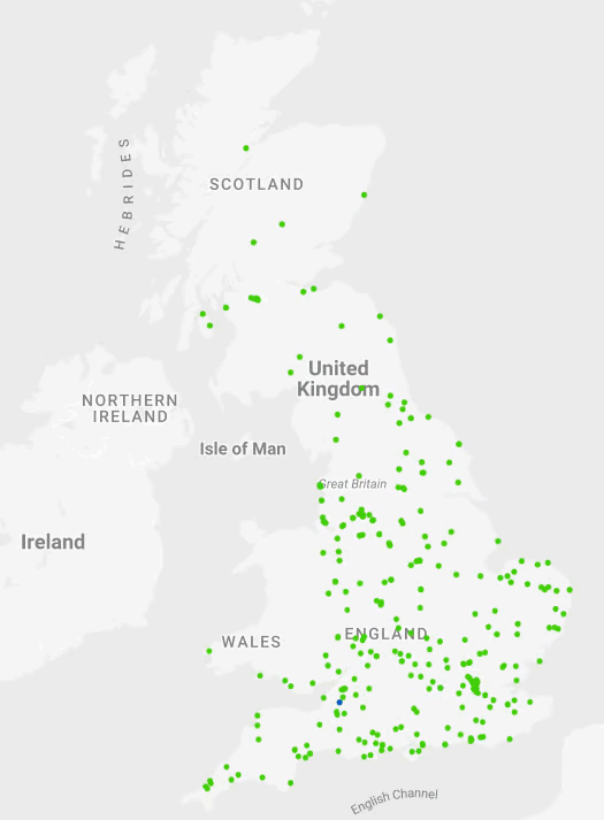
Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

	mainstream pop acts
• **Wireless Festival (London)**	• Centres on hip-hop, grime, and R&B • Hosted in Finsbury Park or Crystal Palace Park in recent years

Planned UK Music Festivals in 2025

- So far, more than 300 music festivals are planned for the summer of 2025
- They range in size from mega-festivals like Glastonbury, to small, boutique festivals like A New Day Festival in Canterbury which will host around 7000 music fans



- **City-based festivals**
  - Examples include Tramlines (Sheffield), and Dot to Dot (Manchester, Bristol)
  - These festivals support up-and-coming artists and local economies
  - Brighton's The Great Escape festival showcases 500 emerging artists from all over the world in more than 30 venues across the city and a pop-up festival site on the beach
- **Indoor concerts and arena shows**
  - Hosted at venues like The O2 (London), AO Arena (Manchester), and Ovo Hydro (Glasgow)
    - Significant arena tours for 2025 include Billie Eilish, Guns 'n' Roses, Coldplay and Iron Maiden

Help me understand

- **Smaller-scale festivals, gigs and live music scenes**
  - Found across UK towns and cities
  - Key venues include:
    - O2 Academy venues (nationwide)
    - King Tut's Wah Wah Hut (Glasgow)
    - Rock City (Nottingham)
    - The Leadmill (Sheffield)
    - Thekla (Bristol)
  - Small venues often promote genres like folk, jazz, punk, electronic, metal and indie
  - Grassroots events often showcase unsigned or early-stage artists
  - They have helped launch major UK acts such as Adele, Ed Sheeran, Arctic Monkeys and Stormzy

Businesses operating in live music events

- Live music events need **many different businesses** to work together
- Each one has a key role, from building the stage to keeping fans safe, selling food, or helping people buy tickets
- Without strong planning and partnerships, the event wouldn't be able to run successfully

1. Promoters

- Promoters plan and run live music events
- They book the artists, organise the venue, manage staff and pay for most of the event costs
  - **Live Nation** is one of the biggest music companies in the world. It runs more than 40,000 events each year and owns many venues. Live Nation works on festivals like Download and Reading & Leeds, and it also owns **Ticketmaster**
  - **Festival Republic**, which is part of Live Nation, runs popular UK festivals like Latitude and Wireless. It organises the whole event, from hiring artists to managing safety and working with councils

2. Venues and infrastructure providers

- These companies supply the physical things that make a live event work. This includes the stage, lights, sound systems, fencing and toilets
  - **Stageco** is a global company that builds large stages for concerts and festivals. It has worked on shows for The Rolling Stones and Glastonbury
  - **PRG** provides sound, lights, and video screens. It works on tours and festivals across the world

3. Security and crowd control

- Security teams keep the audience safe. They check tickets, search bags, help control big crowds, and deal with emergencies
  - **Showsec** is a large UK security company with thousands of trained staff. It helps keep people safe at events like Creamfields and TRNSMT. Showsec works closely with the police and medical teams
  - Other companies like **G4S Events** provide security at music and sports events

4. Food and drink vendors

- These are the stalls and food trucks that sell snacks, meals, and drinks at live music events.
  - Some are **local independent traders**, like a small vegan burger van or a wood-fired pizza truck
  - Others are big brands like **PepsiCo** or **Heineken**, which run official bars or drink stations
  - At festivals like *Green Man* or *Shambala*, organisers choose vendors who use eco-friendly packaging or local food

5. Ticketing platforms

- These companies sell tickets and help people enter the event. They often collect data for event organisers too
  - **Ticketmaster** is the biggest ticket seller in the world. It sells tickets for concerts, festivals, and sports events. It also provides scanning systems at event gates
  - **Dice** is a phone app that sells tickets and stops ticket reselling (scalping). It is popular with younger fans and used by venues like *O2 Academy*. Dice makes it easy to send a ticket to a friend or join a waiting list

6. Sponsors and partners

- Sponsors help pay for the event. In return, they get to advertise and promote their brand at the festival.
  - **Barclaycard** has sponsored *Isle of Wight Festival*, with branded bars and special offers for cardholders
  - Other sponsors include **Carlsberg**, **Coca-Cola**, and **Three** (a phone network). They often run fun branded zones or give out free samples
  - Some sponsors pay for VIP areas, chill-out tents, or competitions to win tickets

Businesses operating at Wireless Festival

- **Wireless Festival** is a large three-day music event held each summer in London
- It focuses mainly on hip-hop, rap, and R&B, with past headliners including Travis Scott, Cardi B, and Stormzy
- The festival attracts over 50,000 people each day
- A range of businesses work together to make the event a success

Promoter	• Festival Republic organises the entire event, including booking headline acts and other performers, working with the council to get event licences, overseeing safety, transport and emergency plans • It also pays upfront costs, expecting to make money from ticket sales, food vendors and sponsors
Infrastructure provision	• PRG supplies the sound systems, lights, and large video screens for the stages • DC Site Services puts up fencing, builds pathways, provides toilets, and manages waste removal • Finsbury Park is a public space that must be transformed into a safe event site and returned to a public spaces after the festival
Security and crowd control	• Showsec is in charge of checking festivalgoers' bags at the gates, making sure crowds don't get too packed near the stage and working with emergency services and backstage crews • Showsec trains staff before the event and follows strict safety rules throughout the festival
Ticketing	• Tickets for Wireless are sold online through Ticketmaster, who handle payments and ticket delivery (mostly via mobile app) and run the entry system with scanners at the gates • Following the event, Ticketmaster provides data to Festival Republic to plan future events
Food and drink	• Wireless offers dozens of food trucks and stalls, selling burgers, noodles, vegan wraps, and frozen drinks. Branded bars sell products from Heineken and other drink sponsors • Some traders are local, while others are national brands with contracts for multiple events

	Three, a phone company, provides free charging stations and a viewing platform for their customers • Pepsi Max runs a branded stage with DJs and photo booths

Live event revenues

- Live music events make money in many different ways

1. Ticket sales, VIP upgrades and parking

- **Ticket sales** are the main way events earn money
  - For example, Reading & Leeds Festival charges over **£300** for a weekend ticket and sells tens of thousands each year
- Many festivals offer **VIP upgrades**
  - At Wireless Festival, VIP ticket holders get access to private bars, luxury toilets and raised viewing platforms — with VIP tickets costing up to **£500**
- **Parking charges** are also common
  - At Download Festival, parking can cost around **£30–50** per vehicle
- **Camping**
  - Festivalgoers often choose to camp for the duration of the event
  - Whilst a standard pitch at Glastonbury is included in the ticket price, a premium is charged for premium pitches and glamping options such as luxury bell tents and camper vans

2. On-site sales: food, drink, merchandise

- Food and drink stalls pay a fee to trade at the festival and sometimes give the organiser a share of their profits
- Prices are higher than normal — a burger can cost **£10**, and a pint of beer **£7–9**
- **Official merchandise** like artist t-shirts or hoodies can sell for **£30–£60**
- Festivals often have their own branded merchandise too, such as caps or reusable cups

3. Sponsorship and branding deals

- Big brands sponsor festivals in return for advertising and exclusive deals.
  - **Barclaycard** has sponsored Isle of Wight Festival, giving customers discounts and running branded bars
  - **Three (the mobile network)** sponsors Wireless Festival, offering customers special areas with free phone charging and better views
- These deals can be worth hundreds of thousands of pounds to the promoter

4. Streaming or broadcasting rights

giving fans around the world a way to watch at home
- These deals bring in extra income and promote the event to a bigger audience

Trends and innovation at live music events

1. Increased use of RFID wristbands and mobile apps

- Many festivals now use **RFID wristbands** instead of tickets. Fans tap them to enter, buy food or drinks and even access VIP areas
    - Isle of Wight Festival and All Points East both use this system
- Festival apps also help fans find stage times, top up cash balances or share their location with friends

2. Focus on sustainability

- Many festivals now try to be more eco-friendly
    - *Glastonbury* bans plastic bottles and encourages reusable cups and bottles
    - *Shambala Festival* runs on **renewable energy** and gives fans the chance to **offset carbon emissions** from their travel
    - Some festivals offer **discounted tickets for people using public transport** or shared travel options

3. Growth in hybrid and digital formats

- Since **COVID-19**, many events offer **online streaming** as well as in-person tickets
    - *Tomorrowland* created a fully digital festival during lockdown with virtual stages
- Even now, festivals use **TikTok, Instagram, or YouTube** to stream performances, backstage clips, and interviews for fans at home

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